It was amazing to see that there were some people coming to these meetings who hadn't had a drop to drink in 10, 15 or even 20 years. Obviously these meetings had helped them stay off the booze. On the other hand, the meetings can also serve as a crutch for these guys, as if you can't actually quit without attending them. To quit cold turkey has got to be tough, though.

I can't imagine living the rest of my life without having the occasional drink. I know that Aussie paceman Brett Lee never touched a drop of alcohol in the year leading up to the 2003 World Cup. That's one helluva effort. You've got to take your hat off to people who can do that.

Back at the clinic, we'd also have our own group meetings, and we would have to take turns to be the group leader, who would voice the concerns of the group. I sort of took over the role a little bit too much and they actually banned me from talking for a few days. I made some valuable contributions, though, during my short tenure in the spotlight. I instilled the importance of little things, like punctuality – I actually asked the counsellors why they were always late. I mean, we arrived on time, at 8.45 a.m., but they'd stroll in only five or ten minutes later. Not on as far as I was concerned. I questioned the kind of example the counsellors were setting.

My comments raised a few eyebrows among the counsellors, but I wasn't trying to be disrespectful. My viewpoint was that we were all in the same boat, trying hard to improve as people. A small issue like punctuality goes a long way in my eyes.

But the counsellors took it well, to be fair to them, and we agreed that anyone who arrived late would be on dishes duty. All the dishes – and there were a lot of them – were washed by hand. It was a kak job. No one was late after that first week. I did dishes *once*, and I wasn't late again. We all had our normal chores to do, which often involved cleaning up or drying, but dishes duty would be in addition to your normal chores. The boys weren't keen for it, hey.

The other issues I raised were the flies and the pool. It was summertime, so it was pretty warm and, unfortunately, the clinic is near a horse farm – which meant there were flies everywhere. Look, the place was very clean, but there just always seemed to be a plague of flies in our dining room, and it's off-putting, you know. I had a word with one of the counsellors and said, 'Listen, you can't allow this, boet. We are bladdy human beings. You